project.org

STUDENT HANDOUT

YELLOW LEVEL
GRADE LEVEL

Coin Detectives

Grades 3–4 · Real or Replica?

ADMIT ONE

NAME _____ DATE _____ CLASS _____

The coins in *In Their Hands* were spent and held in the years of the Gospels. Eight are genuine. Three are museum-quality replicas, honest copies labeled as copies. But how does an expert know an ancient coin is real? Today you are a coin detective.

01

PART 1

Two cases to crack

In each pair one coin is genuine and one is a fake. Look closely at the owl's feathers on the first pair and the curls of the hair on the second.

REAL OR REPLICA? · DEKADRACHM OF ATHENS



COIN A



COIN B

The fake is Coin (A) or Coin (B) (circle one)

REAL OR REPLICA? · LYSIMACHUS TETRADRACHM



COIN A



COIN B

The fake is Coin (A) or Coin (B) (circle one)

02

PART 2

Explain the clues

For each clue, describe what you see on the real coin and on the fake.

CLUE	ON THE REAL COIN	ON THE FAKE
The owl's feathers		
The curls of the hair		
The surface of the metal		

03

PART 3

Struck or cast?

A real ancient coin was *struck*: stamped between two dies. Many fakes are *cast*: hot metal is poured into a mold made from a real coin. Why do you think a cast coin has softer, blurrier details?

04

PART 4

Put five coins in order

Write **1 to 5** in the boxes, from the oldest coin to the newest. **Tip:** BC years count *down* toward the birth of Christ, so 5 BC comes before 1 BC. AD years count *up*.

☐



Pontius Pilate
29/30 AD

☐



Porcius Festus
59–62 AD

☐



Augustus Caesar
5–4 BC

☐



Herod Agrippa I
41–44 AD

☐



Shekel of Tyre (replica)
1 BC–1 AD

05

PART 5

Evidence for the Gospel

Luke 3:1 names the rulers of the time, including the emperor Tiberius and Pontius Pilate. Explain how a real coin made by Pilate helps show that the Gospel happened in a real place and time.

SHARE WITH YOUR FAMILY

Show your family the two pairs. Can they find the fakes? Tell them one clue an expert uses, and which coin in the exhibition was made by the man who put Jesus on trial.